

Internet Explorer Vulnerabilities

The Problem

Mid-June, Microsoft released 12 security updates to fix at least 21 vulnerabilities in Windows and other software, including 12 flaws labelled "critical." At least eight different flaws—four of them critical—have been found in IE. A problem has also been found with Microsoft's implementation of JavaScript: the baddies have been known to use JavaScript flaws to install bad programs. Then there's a flaw in almost every version of Windows Media Player, and a host of other problems have been found as well—including a security hole in Word 2000, XP, and 2003; a critical flaw in PowerPoint—and more!

The Damages

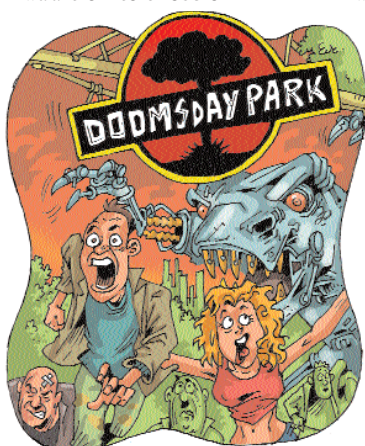
Microsoft calls a vulnerability "critical" if attackers could exploit it without any action on the part of the victim. Critical flaws in IE are especially dangerous because they expose users to the risk of having their computer completely hijacked by visiting a malicious site.

The Solution

You need to immediately install the patches. All the required patches are available via the Microsoft Update Web site (windowsupdate.microsoft.com), or you can activate Automatic Updates on your computer. Office 2000 users will need to also visit Microsoft's Office Update site to download the Office patches separately.

is now at seven minutes to midnight—is holding a series of "doomsday reconsidered" meetings to look at future threats to civilisation. Executive director Kennette Benedict told a radio station that they would be taking stock of the threats that might be catastrophic to humans.

New threats will be investigated at the meeting in addition to those of



atomic weapons and such. Benedict said, "We'll also be looking at new developments in life sciences, in synthetic biology, for instance, and some of the emerging technologies, nanotechnologies, and how these may converge with life and developments in biotechnologies, and we'll also look at information technology and the vulnerabilities of civilian infrastructure."

The BAS has a Web page: www.thebulletin.org.

Scott Borg, the director and chief economist of the US Cyber Consequences Unit—which gives the US

government risk assessments of possible cyber attacks—also recently warned that criminals or terrorists could target IT systems. A key target could be supervisory control and data acquisition systems in power plants and such. Borg told the newspaper *The Independent*, "Think of the control systems for chemical plants, railway lines or manufacturing facilities. Shutting these systems down is a nuisance. Causing them to do the wrong thing at the wrong time is much worse."

So could IT bring about the end of the world? That might be fatalistic thinking, but GNR (Genetics, Nanotechnology, Robotics) technologies are something to reckon with when thinking along these lines. Experiments are

currently on that merge human genes with those of goats and other such animals, recalling images of Greek mythical creatures. Nanotechnology conjures up the image of "grey goo"—swarms of nano-robots spread all over the atmosphere. And as for robotics, we've mentioned elsewhere in this issue that experts are already warning of safety concerns as robots increasingly enter homes and offices.

Technology enables—but it just might destroy. But all this could, of course, be just plain, uninformed, old-fashioned paranoia.

HOT YouTube



The interface here is neat, and videos can be rated. You can save videos to your favourites, add them to groups, and share and blog them. Along with a thumbnail of the video, you also see when the video was posted, its rating, category, and more.

Google Video

NOT



Here you can't comment on videos, and you can't mark a video as a favourite. The interface is clumsy compared to that of YouTube... and there are other little niggles: no view count, and no ratings.

PATENT, WAIT, SUE... AGAIN

Net2Phone And Skype In Silly Legal Spat

Internet phone company Net2Phone, which was a popular paid service in the old days (read 2000) has filed a patent infringement lawsuit against Skype Technologies and its parent company eBay. Net2Phone alleges that Skype has infringed on its VoIP patent, which it applied for in 1995 and which was issued in August 2000.

Skype uses P2P technology for its VoIP service, whereas companies such as AT&T use a system

One Silly Question

"Whom would you compare your computer's IQ to?"



"Laloo Prasad Yadav"
Avit



"Abdul Kalam"
Poojan



"An ostrich!"
Deepal



"Bill Gates!"
Basuri



"The Space Shuttle..."
Pranav